



REMAINS OF THE RAGE: A lone man surveys a church destroyed in the communal violence in Kandhamal

lanes of politics? Or, are you being welcomed by the most successful scion of a regional dynasty? Or, are you with a cultural sophisticate who has come home—and who is still making sense of this goddamn place called home?

Patnaik is more than the sum total of the answers, though, at the moment, he has a war to fight, for the so-called conscience keepers of the endangered nation from UPA and elsewhere have been calling for the imposition of President's rule in the state.

"Do you fear the worst?"

"It's an unfair demand and it's politically motivated as general elections are only a few months away. The state is doing its best and there has been no incidence of violence for the last ten days."

That sounds very ministerial, even in that smoky accent of the chief minister, who in his trademark kurta-pyjama and kolhapuris, is calm, almost serene. CM Cool for the admirers.

"Your secular credentials are being questioned now."

"What can I say? It's a wrong perception, and it's unjustified. I'm secular. Nobody can control perceptions. It's very unfortunate if you are painted

in colours which are not true."

He knows that there is a sudden crisis of image: Patnaik the ruler who cares the least as a volatile part of his state becomes a battleground of hate. He can only afford to be philosophical: "You have to take the good with the bad. When the bad happens, your first priority is to stop it, not to dwell on one's image." And he doesn't think the image of a suave secularist has taken a beating because of his alliance with BJP, for the relationship is based on a "secular and progressive document on governance". So stop accusing him of being soft towards Bajrang Dal and VHP, which have reportedly been leading the tribal rage against the Christian converts of Kandhamal. "Thousands have been arrested, including members of Bajrang Dal and VHP. I received no pressure from BJP at all."

Kandhamal, the latest entry into the Indian glossary of hate, is a lot more complex than the stereotype of Hindu evil versus Christian good. The rivalry between the majority Kondhs (Scheduled Tribes) and the minority Panas (Scheduled Castes) is accentuated by an explosive mix of poverty,

POLITICAL TARGET

"The demand for President's rule is politically motivated as the elections are close."

"I'm secular but I cannot control perceptions. It is unfortunate if you are painted in false colours."